Discussion of Possible Revisions to Board Policy EMI (Local)

Recommendation:
That the Board of Trustees adopt updated Local Board Policy EMI Miscellaneous Instructional Policies: Study of Religion

Explanation:
The Administration presented recommended revisions to Board Policy EMI Miscellaneous Instructional Policies: Study of Religion. The Administration recommends that the updated Local Board Policy EMI be adopted as presented.

Policy Reference: EMI Local

Recommended by:

Dr. Ted Landry
Interim Superintendent of Schools

Teaching About Religion

The inclusion of religion in the study of history, culture, literature, music, drama, and art is essential to a full and fair presentation of the curriculum. The inclusion of religious elements is appropriate as long as the material included is intrinsic to the field of study in which it is presented and as long as it is presented objectively.

The District's approach to teaching about religion shall be academic, not devotional. Emphasis on religious themes in the arts, literature, and history shall be only as extensive as necessary for a balanced and thorough study of these areas. Such studies shall not foster any particular religious tenet nor demean any religious beliefs, but shall attempt to develop mutual respect among students and advance their knowledge and appreciation of the role that religious heritage plays in the social, cultural, and historic development of civilization.

Religious Texts

Use of religious texts in instruction shall be guided by the principles set forth above. Other than texts used in an appropriate course of study, the District shall not distribute religious texts or materials to students. Such materials may be indexed, shelved, and circulated as library materials. [See FNAA regarding student distribution of nonschool literature and GKDA regarding nonstudent distribution of nonschool literature]

Religious Music

District music groups may perform or receive instruction regarding religious music as part of the secular program of instruction. The primary purpose of the inclusion of religious music in performances or instruction shall be academic, not devotional. Performances and instruction shall reflect religious diversity when appropriate.

Religious Symbols

Religious symbols may be displayed as a teaching aid. Their display shall be temporary and limited to specific teaching activities; such displays shall not be permitted for devotional purposes.

Religious Elements In Student Work

Students may choose to include religious elements in their schoolwork, such as papers, presentations, or artwork; however, students' work must fulfill the purpose of the assignment and be evaluated by secular academic standards.

Ten Commandments

Notwithstanding any conflicting provisions contained elsewhere in this or other policy, each classroom shall be required to clearly display the Ten Commandments in a conspicuous location. Classroom is defined as any learning environment in which instruction is provided to students. This requirement shall constitute an expressed exception to any general rules to the contrary.

The Ten Commandments shall:

1. Be displayed as a durable poster or framed copy, measuring at least 16 inches wide and 20 inches tall;
2. Be legible to a person with average vision from anywhere in the classroom in which the poster or framed copy is displayed;
3. Read exactly as outlined below:
    a. The Ten Commandments
    b. I AM the LORD thy God.
    c. Thou shalt have no other gods before me.
    d. Thou shalt not make to thyself any graven images.
    e. Thou shalt not take the Name of the Lord thy God in vain.
    f. Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy.
    g. Honor thy father and thy mother, that thy days may be long upon the land which the Lord thy God giveth thee.
    h. Thou shalt not kill.
    i. Thou shalt not commit adultery.
    j. Thou shalt not steal.
    k. Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor.
    l. Thou shalt not covet thy neighbor's house.
    m. Thou shalt not covet thy neighbor's wife, nor his manservant, nor his maidservant, nor his cattle, nor anything that is thy neighbor's.

4. Not contain additional text or content beyond what is required.

If there are any classrooms that do not include a poster or framed copy of the Ten Commandments, the District must accept any offer from a private donor to comply with the requirements.

If there are any classrooms that do not include a poster or framed copy of the Ten Commandments, the District may utilize district funds to comply with the requirements.

There shall be no exemption to this requirement.